

Episode 156: Long Ago... 94 1995 Part 14 Persistence by the Colour Copier in August

Today as I write this manuscript is February 11th, National Foundation Day, and amazingly, Tokyo is getting heavy snow! Last week I wrote "couldn't it snow and accumulate properly just once?" and amazingly, it's actually snowing! Oh, the weather god must have read my previous writing (laugh).

Though some people may be inconvenienced by the snow, please forgive me everyone. This is Tokyo's first real snow of winter. It's cold but I'm enjoying it.

Anyway.

Days of part-time work and Okubo-san's practical Mac course in the "work room" I made by renting an apartment room in front of Nakano Station proceeded in parallel with *Neighbourhood Story* steadily progressing toward September broadcast at Oizumi Studio. Main story work was various, but my current big problem was remaining promotional still work. The "stills with computer image processing added" ordered by Producer Seki.

Setting aside the "computer image processing? What should I do?" problem for a moment, I had to create digital materials for it anyway.

First, scan animation with a scanner. I had to think about resolution. What values should I capture at? Now I could immediately answer "ah, for stills used that way, about 288dpi is fine," but lacking experience, I didn't understand those guidelines well.

"Basically, just use resolution where lines don't look jagged" - well, that's right (bitter laugh). I actually consulted Okubo-sensei(!) about this too. Okubo-san taught me the principles and guidelines. Unless it's vector images, in principle, the higher the resolution, the less jagged lines appear. But if you honestly go too high-resolution and data becomes large, you hit computer processing limits and it stops working, or takes

deadly amounts of time. I'd done such experiments myself. So I understood to some degree that working with unreasonably large data was impossible. So I shouldn't make data too large.

Moreover, digital data submission was still nonexistent then, so digital still data had to be printed out once, then amazingly photographed with still cameras like other cel + background stills, and those positives delivered and submitted. So if printed lines didn't look jagged, and print size was roughly the same as cel + background stills, A4 to at most B4 was OK. So I think the first still was made from roughly A4-size animation master at about 300dpi resolution. But even that size would later plunge us into hellish waiting times...

Now for work. Binarize imported animation line art data. Colour the binarized line art data with colouring tools. I used Adobe's Photoshop for both animation import and colouring work. Now, line art import and binarization use Traceman, colouring uses Paintman - digital colouring specialised software has differentiated, but such convenient things didn't exist then. Working bit by bit in Photoshop with a mouse, finished data was temporarily saved on MO discs that could store large capacity. Work up to here was done on a Mac installed in a corner of the finishing colour direction room, but work from combining with backgrounds through processing to printing was done on another Mac installed in a corner of the 2nd floor copy room in the same studio. This Mac was connected to a colour copier, perfect for checking while printing.

That evening, gathered in front of the copy room Mac were Producer Seki, Umezawa-san, Gyo-san, Yukie-san, Production Manager Kazama-san, and me. Starting work from combining my prepared colouring data with background data Gyo-san had worked on and brought as layers.

"So, what should we do?" I asked.

"First, you know this colour illustration processed on Yazawa-sensei's Mac? Can't we do this kind of atmosphere?" said Seki-san.

Ah, I see. That illustration was processed into night-like colouring and finished with an overall rough texture. Naturally, what was done how to create such images was unknown (laugh). Anyway, I started by watching and learning. I thought if I tried and fiddled around, somehow it would work! I began thinking like that. First try adjusting tone from above to create somewhat similar colouring, then to fiddle with image texture, try adding noise, blurring, testing various filters. But this became quite difficult.

This work also involved Photoshop processing, but it took enormous time. Trying one filter effect took several minutes of calculation processing for that single processing. As I wrote before, this PowerMacintosh 8100AV of the time, despite saying "Power~," had specs incomparable to today's machines. Moreover, image weight exceeded expectations. That's right. When background data was added, it became surprisingly large and heavy data, and that weight further hindered calculation processing. Furthermore, Photoshop then had no undo function - if something failed, you had to start over from the beginning. So we saved repeatedly at work stages. Each save, disc writing, also took several minutes...

Work progressed like that, but when we gave tentative OK on monitor and actually printed, it was somehow unsatisfactory. So which parts to reprocess how... back to data temporarily saved at earlier stages for correction work. Each operation took enormous time again. Print, correct, repeat. Getting tired led to more silly mistakes, retreating to saved points and rebuilding work and waiting.

Everyone waited by that narrow colour copier watching the work screen through such repeated work. The clock hands reached midnight. Ultimately, giving OK to two stills took until near dawn.